to Kennedy's authorisation of the CIA operation to overthrow Castro in April 1961.[7]

Castro's revolution also needs to be understood in the context of US-Cuban relations, dating back to at least the nineteenth century. In December 1823 the US President, James Monroe, proclaimed to Congress that 'we should consider any attempt [by European powers] … to extend their system to any portion of this hemisphere as dangerous to our peace and safety.'[8] The 'Monroe doctrine' provided a rationale for Washington's regional policy and the idea that Cuba was in 'America's backyard'. That perception underpinned US intervention in Cuba's war of national liberation against Spain between 1895 and 1898, which ended 400 years of especially brutal Spanish colonial rule.

However, far from creating a genuinely sovereign nation, President Theodore Roosevelt made clear that Washington had the right to intervene to protect US interests. In 1901 the Platt Amendment to the Army Administration Bill established a quasi-protectorate over Cuba. The Cuban-American Treaty of 1903 then granted the right of US intervention in Cuban affairs and the right to maintain naval bases on the island. The result was the establishment of the first US overseas military base, at Guantánamo Bay, in 1903, which was leased to the United States in perpetuity.

In 1934 President Franklin D. Roosevelt accepted the abrogation of the Platt Amendment as part of his 'Good Neighbour Policy'. This repudiated the idea of intervention and sought reciprocity in trading arrangements with Central and South America. Nonetheless, a treaty in 1934 agreed the continuation of Guantánamo Bay as a US naval base. For many Cubans, Guantánamo remains a continuing affront to Cuban national dignity. In 1962, when Khrushchev and Kennedy agreed the removal of Soviet missiles, Castro unsuccessfully sought a broader regional settlement that *inter alia* would entail US withdrawal from its naval base. After 2003 Guantánamo achieved lasting notoriety as a place of incarceration for suspected jihadi terrorists who were subjected to degrading and inhumane treatment, and, in some cases, torture. Yet, had events turned out differently in October 1962, Guantánamo would have occupied a very different place in history. Unbeknownst to its US defenders, the Soviets deployed a